"Love… there's a word that's foreign to you boyo. I don't think you can feel it" (Brian Azzarello)

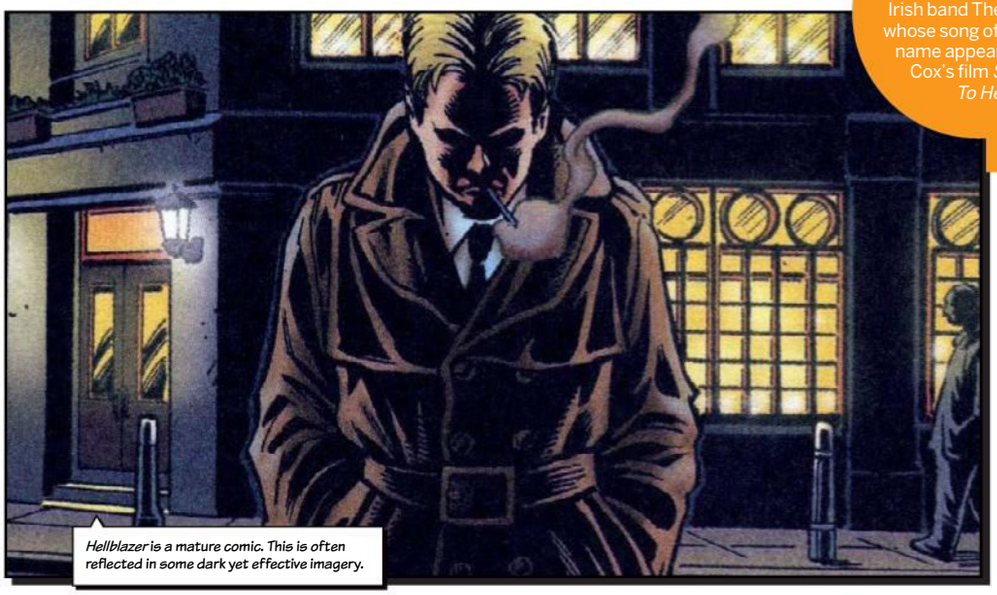
surprised that the character has survived two-and-a-half decades: "A toast: To John Constantine, on the occasion of his 25th Anniversary… How have you managed to last so long? You're vain, cruel and self-serving; there's not one charitable bone in your body. You don't do anything good unless you're pushed to the wall, or it ultimately benefits you to do so. You treat your friends like weak shit on your shoes, and have a deeper respect for thems you despise than for those that love you. Love… there's a word that's foreign to you boyo, eh? I don't think you can feel it. Sure, you're pantomime loving – that's part of the con – but at the end of the day, it's always been all about you, hasn't it? So how'd you last so long? Because you're just like us, Con-Job. Chin chin, you arrogant bastard."

Azzarello's run took Constantine out of London and England to the USA, where Moore first introduced readers to him. But reaction was mixed to his stories and Vertigo obviously took note because the next writer was another Brit, Mike Carey. A former teacher and Oxford graduate, Carey brought magic back to the title and harkened back to both the Delano and Ennis run in terms of its general feel and cast of characters. He was already the writer of Vertigo's *Lucifer* series, so bringing him to *Hellblazer* made perfect sense, as his grasp of the supernatural juxtaposed with the mundane was already proven. Carey spent 40 issues on the title, the longest tenure of any single creator, and his run is generally well regarded by both readers and critics alike.

He seemed to have a good handle on what made the character tick and, for him, Constantine's longevity is easily explained as he pointed out to us recently. "There are a lot of different answers to that question, I think. For me, a big part of the appeal has always been the tension between John's life and John's voice. He's an initiate into every mystery imaginable – a guy who walks a shamanistic path and converses with gods and monsters. But he talks in a way that's sardonic, smutty, irreverent, insolent, fundamentally unimpressed. He's an everyman character, but specifically, everyman looking into the face of God and saying, 'How's it going, mate? Moved on the face of the waters lately?' Or, 'How'd you manage to get a six-day week without being in a union?'" he said.

It was during Carey's run that the film based on the character, *Constantine*, was released (2005). Starring Keanu Reeves and directed by pop promo director Francis Lawrence, the plot was loosely based on Ennis's *Dangerous Habits* story. But Reeves was an odd choice to play Constantine and switching the setting from London to LA proved to be an unpopular decision with the comic readers who'd followed the character for 20 years. However, the film did take $230 million at the box office, but while there continues to be the occasional internet rumour about a follow-up, this film buried any future appearances by John Constantine on the big screen.

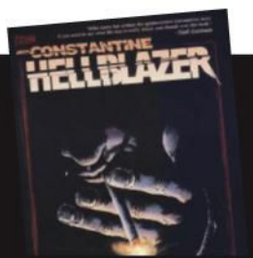
The story *Rake At The Gates Of Hell* is a reference to London Irish band The Pogues, whose song of the same name appears in Alex Cox's film *Straight To Hell*.



Hellblazer is a mature comic. This is often reflected in some dark yet effective imagery.

Denise Mina was the first woman to tackle *Hellblazer*, but while the Scottish crime writer spent a year on the book, her run never really found its feet. Next, Mike Carey returned for a single issue after Mina, something that had become a bit of a tradition, and then the next writer to steer his destiny was Andy Diggle. Diggle had started as editor of *2000 AD*, a role that he used to set himself up as a writer on series like *Lenny Zero* and *Snow/Tiger* for *Judge Dredd Megazine*. He had written the *Hellblazer* spin-off miniseries *Lady Constantine* back in 2003, so his appointment made sense editorially. In terms of tone, Diggle stayed close to what Carey had established for the character but it lacked the spark of Carey or Ennis. He was on the book for just under two years, but only time will tell if his efforts will be remembered with fondness or not. When **SciFiNow** spoke to him to ask about Constantine's anniversary, Diggle had obviously given it quite a bit of thought.

"They say that inside every cynic is a disappointed idealist, and I think that pretty much nails John Constantine. I'd disagree with those who say he doesn't



All His Engines, original graphic novel (2005)
Writer: Mike Carey
Artist: Leonardo Manco
Constantine has to prevent a plague that's afflicting children across London, a quest that leads him to LA. This is one of the creepiest JC stories ever, thanks partly to Manco's seriously deranged artwork.



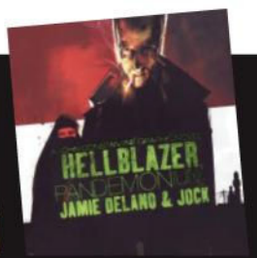
Haunted & Setting Sun, issues 134-143 (1999)
Writer: Warren Ellis
Artists: Various
Even though Ellis was on the book less than a year, he made a huge impact on the character. Taking us on a tour of London using JC as our guide, Ellis puts extra flesh on the protagonist's bones.



Joyride, issues 230-237 (2007)
Writer: Andy Diggle
Artist: Leonardo Manco
Andy Diggle's initial storyline looked at supernatural violence on a South London housing estate and displayed a deft hand with the character. It remains one of the most accessible modern *Hellblazer* arcs.



Dark Entries (2009)
Writer: Ian Rankin
Artist: Werther Dell'edera
While *Dark Entries* is flawed artistically, Rankin turns in a solid effort looking at the modern phenomena of reality television. The famed author is one of a number of high-profile prose writers who have ventured into Constantine's world.



Pandemonium (2010)
Writer: Jamie Delano
Artist: Jock
Delano's return to the character was explosive, showing that he's never lost his affinity for the character, and *Pandemonium* was also ably abetted by accomplished interior work by noted cover artist Jock. A perfect way to celebrate the character's anniversary.

